

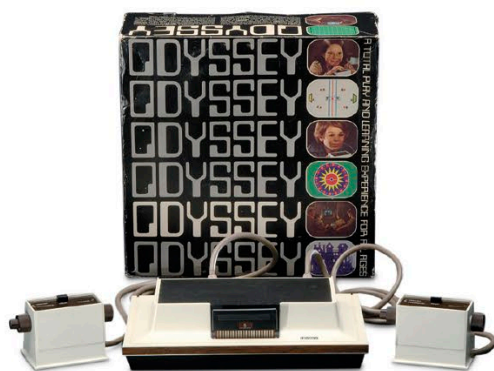
Video games

The first computers were built to perform serious tasks such as cracking enemy codes. But, in the 1950s, university researchers started using them for creating fun video games. These early experiments led to the development of the first home video game consoles in the early 1970s. Since then, video games have grown into one of the world's most popular forms of entertainment.

First home gaming system

- **What?** The Magnavox Odyssey
- **Who?** Ralph H. Baer
- **Where and when?** US, 1972

The first video game console that could be connected to a television set featured simple games, such as *Table Tennis*. The console was a success and an inspiration for many imitators—kick-starting an entire industry.



WOW!

The first video game is believed to be *Tennis for Two*, devised by the American physicist William Higinbotham in 1958.



The joystick controls the player's movement on screen.

Cartridge games

- **What?** Atari 2600
- **Who?** Atari, Nolan Bushnell, and Ted Dabney
- **Where and when?** US, 1977

Atari dominated the home video game market in the 1970s. While earlier consoles could play only the pre-installed games, the Atari 2600 gave more options—it was one of the first systems to use games stored on separate cartridges. It helped popularize some of the biggest games of the age, including *Space Invaders* and *Donkey Kong*.



Japanese gaming

- **What?** Nintendo Entertainment System
- **Who?** Nintendo
- **Where and when?** Japan, 1983

The video game industry was initially dominated by the US, but Japan took over in the 1980s following the introduction of the Nintendo Entertainment System (NES). It became the biggest selling console of the time—owned by around a third of all American households.

The bulky joystick was replaced by slimmer, cross-shaped joy pads and buttons.



NES Classic Edition, 1985

Handheld consoles

- **What?** Nintendo Gameboy
- **Who?** Nintendo, Satoru Okada
- **Where and when?** Japan, 1989

With the release of the Gameboy, Nintendo came to dominate the handheld console market in the 1990s and 2000s. In 2004, it released the Nintendo DS, which sold more than 154 million to become the biggest selling handheld console ever. These consoles helped to popularize character-driven games, such as *Super Mario Brothers*.